

Daphne Palette

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

Sterling knew you quietly sold a work you had publicly promised to donate to another institution and planned to expose the contradiction.

What you are hiding

You sold it to cover a failed business investment and hoped to replace it before anyone noticed. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Protect your private complication until you decide disclosure helps you.
- Use your public relationships to trade information rather than waiting for clues to come to you.
- Ask at least two people where they were during the poisoning window.

What you know about other guests

- Julian has been quietly buying back his own early work through proxies.
- Theo was the anonymous bidder who beat Sterling at the auction that damaged their relationship.

Notes / Who will you speak to first?

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

Theo and Grant were both with you discussing an auction lot during the key window.

IF MURDERER

You entered at 6:45 with a gift pledge, poisoned the drink, and left lipstick on the decanter stopper.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card B. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card A. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I sold a work I had once spoken of as a future donation because a business investment went badly, and I hoped to replace it before anyone noticed. Sterling planned to expose the contradiction. Theo and Grant can place me with them during the poisoning window. Hypocrisy, yes. Homicide, no.

IF MURDERER

Sterling loved philanthropy most when it made someone else look smaller. He was going to expose my broken promise as entertainment. I went to the salon with a pledge card, poisoned his cordial, and left a trace on the stopper. Taste can disguise many things. Apparently not this.

Investigation notes
